Company', they also sought illicit help from government servants and were 'gladly obliged'.[48]

Lawley's position hardened further. On 1 December, more than six months later, he observed in Tuticorin: 'it bids me be assured that the sinister influences which have been recently at work—influences bearing their mark in acts of violence—are no longer at work and it inspires me with the hope that they are vanished forever.'[49] Reporting on what transpired then, Wynch reported to Ashe, 'We managed to relegate Mr K.R. Guruswami Aiyar to the back premises in Tuticorin and I had the pleasure of telling his Hon'ble brother [K.R. Venkatarama Aiyar] that I could not recommend H.E. to pay him any special mark of respect.'[50]

## The Government Meddles

The government did not stop at harassing the company and its employees. With VOC safely in prison, it now began to poke directly into its affairs to ensure its obliteration. Leading up to the proceedings against VOC, there were long demi-official exchanges between Wynch in Tirunelveli and the governor, his council and officers in Madras/Ootcamund. The day-to-day functioning of the company's affairs, especially its finances, was discussed and strategies were devised to crush it.

One of the earliest communications was by Wynch, two weeks after VOC's arrest. Wynch had probably been looking into the company's records to see how he could corner it. Though the details he had gathered were garbled or even wrong, they underscore his unhealthy interest in its affairs.

> I was wrong in saying they have purchased the steamers. They are chartered and are being paid for by instalments … The first regular services between Colombo and Tuticorin began in April [1907]. There was a boat before (the one no doubt which you personally saw) but the owners apparently sold it as something untoward occurred and the service was not started …[51]